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Axe, adze

1.1.9.3 Axe, adze

References:

Hebrew בַּרְזֶל (barzel) DEU 19:5, 2KI 6:5, 2KI 6:6, ISA 10:34

Hebrew גַּרְזֶן (garzen) DEU 19:5, DEU 20:19, 1KI 6:7, ISA 10:15

Hebrew מַעֲצָד (maʿatsad) JER 10:3

Hebrew קַרְדֹּם (qardom) JDG 9:48, 1SA 13:20, 1SA 13:21, PSA 74:5, JER 46:22

Greek ἀξίνη (axinē) MAT 3:10, LUK 3:9

Greek πέλεκυς (pelekus) LJE 1:13

Description:

Adze with wooden handle (Metropolitan Museum of Art, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons)The axe or adze was an instrument with a metal, sharp-edged head attached to a wooden handle about the length of a man's arm. The handle was usually wedged tightly into a hole opposite the sharp blade, and it could be held more firmly in place by cords bound around the head and handle. The blade of the axe (*garzen*) was parallel to the handle, while the blade of the adze (*qardom*) was perpendicular to the handle.

Usage:

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Various bronze socketed axe and adze heads, Syria and Iran (2nd-1st millenia BCE, San Antonio Museum of Art, Near Eastern collection) (© Zereshk, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)It was used to cut down trees and woody plants as well as to chop them into smaller pieces. It could also serve as a carpenter's tool for shaping wood.

Translation:

It is likely that the axe mentioned in LJE 1:13 is a kind of weapon rather than a work tool. While the general form of the implement was the same, some languages may make a distinction between the work tool and the weapon. It is also possible to translate the first half of this verse more generally; for example, "Sometimes they are holding weapons."